

LUNAR STRUCTURAL CODE (LSC): A PROPOSED DESIGN STANDARD FOR IN- SITU CONSTRUCTION AND LAVA TUBE HABITATS

Document Reference: LSC-2026-STD-01 | Status: Proposal for Planetary Structural Design Code |

Date: 21 August 2026

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ABSTRACT: This research proposal presents the complete framework for the "Lunar Structural Code" (LSC), a unified deterministic engineering design standard tailored for construction in extreme extraterrestrial environments. Addressing structural mechanics under low-gravity (1/6th Earth g), ultra-high vacuum, extreme thermal cycling ($\Delta T \approx 250$ K), space radiation, and micrometeorite risks, the LSC establishes unified safety factors, geotechnical evaluation rules for subterranean basaltic lava tubes, performance classes for 3D-printed lunar regolith concrete, hybrid composite pressure-vessel mechanics, thermal expansion allowances, and non-destructive testing (NDT) quality verification protocols.

1 . INTRODUCTION & SCOPE

- 1.1 Purpose: To define a standardized Limit State Design (LSD) methodology for load-bearing surface structures and subterranean lava tube habitats on the Moon.
- 1.2 Scope of Application: Pressurized crew habitats, unpressurized protective shields, surface landing pads, vertical thermal barriers, regolith retainment walls, and subterranean rock anchorage systems.

2. PART 1 : GENERAL DESIGN CRITERIA & SAFETY FACTORS

2.1 Partial Safety Factors for Actions (γ_f)

Clause	Action / Load Type	Symbol	ULS Factor (γ_f)	SLS Factor (γ_f)
1.1.1	Dead Load ($g_{\text{moon}} = 1.62 \text{ m/s}^2$)	γ_G	1.20	1.00
1.1.2	Internal Habitat Pressure (1.0 atm = 101.3 kPa)	γ_P	1.50	1.00
1.1.3	Thermal Actions (Surface Environment)	γ_{Tk}	1.35	1.00
1.1.4	Thermal Actions (Lava Tube Interior: -20°C)	γ_{Ti}	1.10	1.00
1.1.5	Seismic Action (Deep/Shallow Moonquakes)	γ_E	1.25	1.00
1.1.6	Regolith Shielding Overburden Load	γ_R	1.30	1.00
1.1.7	Micrometeorite Impact / Dynamic Load	γ_I	1.40	1.00

2.2 Material Safety Factors (γ_m)

- Clause 1.2.1: Lunar Regolith Geopolymer Concrete (γ_c) = 1.60
- Clause 1.2.2: Microwave/Solar Sintered Regolith Bricks (γ_b) = 1.50
- Clause 1.2.3: Earth-Imported T ensile Composites / Fabrics (γ_f) = 1.25
- Clause 1.2.4: Structural Metallic Elements (Titanium / A luminum A lloys) (γ_{m0}) = 1.10

2.3 Ultimate Limit State (ULS) Load Combinations

- Surface Exposed Habitat (LC-01): $W_d = 1.20 G_k + 1.50 P_k + 1.35 T_k + 1.40 I_k$
- Subterranean Lava Tube Habitat (LC-02): $W_d = 1.20 G_k + 1.50 P_k + 1.10 T_i + 1.30 R_k \text{Seismic}$
- Operational Event (LC-03): $W_d = 1.00 G_k + 1.20 P_k + 1.25 E_k$

3. PART 2: GEOTECHNICAL DESIGN & LAVA TUBE STABILITY

3.1 Lunar Basalt Rock Mass Rating System (RMRL)

Clause	Rock Class	Description	Unconfined Compressive Strength (f_{uc})	Rock Quality Designation (RQD)	Design Tensile Strength (f_{rt})
2.1.1	Class A	Intact Basalt Host Rock	> 150 MPa	90% - 100%	12.0 MPa
2.1.2	Class B	Moderately Jointed Rock	100 - 150 MPa	75% - 90%	8.0 MPa
2.1.3	Class C	Highly Jointed / Fractured	50 - 100 MPa	50% - 75%	3.0 MPa
2.1.4	Class D	Micro-fractured / Brecciated	< 50 MPa	< 50%	Neglect (0 MPa)

3.2 Anchorage Systems for Uplift Containment

Clause	Anchor System	Mechanism	Partial Safety Factor (γ_{anc})
2.2.1	Mechanical Expansion Anchors	Dry Mechanical Interlock	2.00
2.2.2	Polymer Resin Anchors	Vacuum-Curing Chemical Bond	1.65
2.2.3	Sintered Basalt Thermal Pins	Thermal Fusion to Host Rock	1.45

4. PART 3: 3D PRINTED LUNAR REGOLITH CONCRETE SPECIFICATIONS

4.1 Material Classes

Clause	Class	Production Technology	Compressive Strength (f_{ck})	Tensile Strength (f_{tk})	Elastic Modulus (E_{cm})
3.1.1	LRC-A	In-situ Alkali-Activated Geopolymer	35 MPa	3.5 MPa	22 GPa

Clause	Class	Production Technology	Compressive Strength (f_{ck})	Tensile Strength (f_{tk})	Elastic Modulus (E_{cm})
3.1.2	LRC-B	Sulphur-bound Lunar Concrete	25 MPa	2.0 MPa	18 GPa
3.1.3	SR-3D	Solar / Microwave Sintered Regolith	65 MPa	5.0 MPa	35 GPa

4.2 Inter-layer Interface Reduction Factors (η_{lay})

- Parallel to Print Bed Compression: $\eta_{lay} = 0.90$
- Perpendicular Direct Tension (Inter-layer Bonding): $\eta_{lay} = 0.65$ Inter-layer
- Vertical Shear Plane Strength: $\eta_{lay} = 0.55$

5. PART 4: INTERNAL PRESSURE SHELLS & HYBRID STRUCTURES

5.1 Tensile Hoop Stress Rule

$$\sigma_d = (\gamma_P \cdot P_{int} \cdot r) / t \leq f_{td}$$

5.2 Composite Hybrid Reinforcement Rule

To prevent massive wall thicknesses under internal pressurization, primary hoop tensile stresses shall be shared between the 3D printed compressive shell and high-strength circumferential ties (Titanium Grade 5 or Carbon Composite Winding).

6. PART 5: THERMAL ACTIONS & EXPANSION JOINTS

- Clause 5.1: Design Surface Thermal Differential: $\Delta T_k = 250 \text{ K}$ (-130°C to +120°C).
- Clause 5.2 Expansion Joint Spacing: Unreinforced surface concrete elements require mechanical expansion joints at intervals not exceeding 12.0 meters ($\Delta L = \alpha_T \cdot L_0 \cdot \Delta T$). Clause 5.3 Isolation
- Breaks: Metallic structural penetrations passing through regolith envelopes must incorporate composite zirconia/aerogel thermal isolators.

7. PART 6: QUALITY CONTROL & TESTING PROTOCOLS

7.1 Non-Destructive Testing (NDT) Matrix

Clause	Target Structural Component	NDT Inspection Method	Acceptance Standard
6.1.1	3D Printed Concrete Wall	Ultrasonic Pulse Velocity (UPV)	Internal Void Volume < 2.0%
6.1.2	Inflatable Internal Membrane	Acoustic Emission (AE) Leak Sensing	Leakage Rate < 0.01 mbar·L/s
6.1.3	Lava Tube Rock Anchors	Ground Penetrating Radar (GPR)	100% Bond Line Integrity

7.2 Proof Testing & Structural Health Monitoring

- Clause 6.2 Proof Pressurization: All pressure-retaining envelopes must withstand $1.25 \times P_{int}$ for 24 hours prior to crew occupancy.
- Clause 6.3 Real-time Monitoring: Continuous embedded Fiber Bragg Grating (FBG) optical strain sensor networks are required across all primary structural joints.

8. DETAILED DESIGN VERIFICATION EXAMPLE (COMPLETE CALCULATIONS)

8.1 Problem Statement & Inputs

- Structure Type: Cylindrical Habitat inside Lava Tube
- Habitat Radius (r): 5.0 m = 5000 mm
- Internal Operating Pressure (P_{int}): 101.3 kPa = 0.1013 N/mm² (1.0 atm)
- Material Selection: Class LRC-A Geopolymer Concrete (f_{ck} = 35 N/mm², f_{tk} = 3.5 N/mm²)
- Reinforcement Material: Titanium Grade 5 Hoop Cables (f_{yk} = 880 N/mm²)

8.2 Step-by-Step Strength Calculations

A. Design Pressure (P_d):

$$P_d = \gamma_P \times P_{int} = 1.50 \times 0.1013 \text{ N/mm}^2 = 0.152 \text{ N/mm}^2$$

B. Concrete Design Tensile Strength (f_{td}):

$$f_{td} = \eta_{lay} \times (f_{tk} / \gamma_c) = 0.65 \times (3.5 \text{ N/mm}^2 / 1.60) = 1.42 \text{ N/mm}^2$$

C. Titanium Reinforcement Design Tensile Strength (f_{tyd}):

$$f_{tyd} = f_{yk} / \gamma_{m0} = 880 \text{ N/mm}^2 / 1.10 = 800 \text{ N/mm}^2$$

8.3 Structural Options Comparison

Option A: Unreinforced Concrete Shell (Cables None)

$$t_{req} \geq (P_d \cdot r) / f_{td} = (0.152 \times 5000) / 1.42 = 535.2 \text{ mm} \rightarrow \text{Adopt } 540 \text{ mm}$$

Option B: Hybrid Reinforced Shell (80% Load to Titanium Cables, 20% to Concrete)

- Pressure on Concrete (P_{conc}) = $0.20 \times 0.152 = \mathbf{0.0304 \text{ N/mm}^2}$
- Pressure on Titanium Cables (P_{cable}) = $0.80 \times 0.152 = \mathbf{0.1216 \text{ N/mm}^2}$

1. Reduced Concrete Wall Thickness (t_{new}):

$$t_{new} \geq (P_{conc} \cdot r) / f_{td} = (0.0304 \times 5000) / 1.42 = 107.04 \text{ mm} \rightarrow \text{Adopt } 110 \text{ mm}$$

2. Titanium Reinforcement Area Required ($A_{s,ti}$) per Meter Length:

$$T_{cable} = P_{cable} \times r \times L = 0.1216 \times 5000 \times 1000 = 608,000 \text{ N / meter length}$$

$$A_{s,ti} = T_{cable} / f_{tyd} = 608,000 \text{ N} / 800 \text{ N/mm}^2 = 760 \text{ mm}^2 \text{ per meter length}$$

3. Cable Detailing:

- Using Ø12 mm T itanium Wires (Cross-sectional A rea = 11 3.1 mm²)
- Number of wires required per meter = 760 / 11 3.1 = 6.72 → 7 Cables per meter Spacin
- g: 1 Cable placed every 140 mm along the shell height.

8.4 Summary of Structural Performance Comparison

Design Parameter	Option A (Unreinforced)	Option B (Hybrid Reinforced)	Engineering Advantage
Wall Thickness (t)	540 mm	110 mm	79.6% Reduction in Material Volume
Concrete Volume (per 1m height)	17.80 m³	3.58 m³	Massive reduction in 3D print time & energy
Earth Transport Mass	0 kg	6.0 kg/m (Titanium)	Highly efficient payload-to-strength ratio
Failure Mode	Brittle Tension Failure	Ductile Tensile Yielding	Fail-safe structural behavior

8.5 Rock Anchor Design for Habitat Uplift

Uplift Force (F_{up}) = $P_d \times \text{Surface Area} = 0.152 \text{ N/mm}^2 \times (10000 \text{ mm} \times 1000 \text{ mm}) = 1,520 \text{ kN per meter length}$

Design Anchor Force ($F_{anc,d}$) = $\gamma_{anc} \times F_{up} = 1.65 \times 1520 \text{ kN} = 2,508 \text{ kN / meter}$

Requirement: 10 Resin Anchors (250 kN capacity each) per meter length (5 anchors per side).

9. CONCLUSION

The proposed Lunar Structural Code (LSC) establishes a rigorous engineering design basis for sustainable extra-terrestrial habitation. By integrating partial safety factors, hybrid material mechanics, and standardized geotechnical checks, the code proves that structural mass transported from Earth can be minimized while ensuring structural reliability under extreme extraterrestrial environments.

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